Election Night, Hour by Hour: Polls Close and Counting Begins

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On Tuesday, voters across the United States will finish choosing members of Congress and governors, and then the counting begins.

Polls close at different times in different states, starting at 7 p.m. Eastern Time and ending at 1 a.m. Eastern Time, when Alaska finishes. That is why election night unfolds in waves, like a long scoreboard lighting up state by state.

Early attention will go to Georgia and Florida. Georgia has a Senate race and a closely watched governor's race, and Georgia **Secretary of State** Brad Raffensperger has told local news that new laws require counties to report results within an hour of polls closing. Florida also has a governor's race and a Senate race, and, according to the Cook Political Report, seven **competitive** House races.

As more polls close, attention spreads. **Competitive** Senate races in North Carolina, Ohio, South Carolina and Maine could help decide control of the Senate. Later, Senate races in Iowa, Kansas, Michigan and Texas will also be watched closely, along with governor's races in states including Arizona.

Control of the House could become clear sooner because of bigger **margins**, while control of the Senate could take much longer. The **margins** there are tighter, seven states are especially **competitive**, and two states use **ranked choice voting**, which can prolong counting.

California closes later and is described as a slow-counting state, so some of its races may not be called quickly. Alaska is last, and its results could take weeks to be **finalized** because it uses **ranked choice voting**.

Vote counting will start Tuesday night, but it could go on for days or even weeks before every close race is settled.

Word Treasure

competitive -- Close and hard to call, because the sides are fairly evenly matched.

margins -- The amounts by which one side leads or wins over another.

ranked choice voting -- A voting system described in the article as one that can prolong counting in the states that use it.

finalized -- Completed and made official at the end of a process.

Secretary of State -- A state official; Georgia's Brad Raffensperger is named in the article in this role.

Background you need

On election day in the United States, voters choose members of Congress and governors, and counting begins once polls close.

Polls close at different times in different states, so results arrive in waves across the night rather than all at once.

Control of the House and the Senate depends on the results of many separate races, and close races can take longer to settle.

Some states are slower to count, and ranked choice voting can prolong counting, so some results may take days or weeks to be finalized.

Break it down

LEAD: On Tuesday, US voters finish choosing members of Congress and governors, then counting begins.

KEY EVENT: Polls close in waves, starting at 7 p.m. Eastern Time and ending at 1 a.m. when Alaska finishes.

+- EARLY FOCUS: Georgia and Florida, with Senate, governor's and House races to watch

+- LATER FOCUS: Senate races across more states that could decide control of the Senate

EVIDENCE: Control of the House could become clear sooner because of bigger margins, while Senate margins are tighter.

OPEN QUESTION: Counting could go on for days or weeks before every close race is settled.

Why it matters

These races decide who controls the House and the Senate, which shapes the laws the country makes. Learning why results arrive slowly also helps people stay patient instead of expecting every answer on election night.

Test what you remember

1. **At what time do the first polls close on Tuesday?**
   - (A) Within an hour of opening
   - (B) 1 a.m. Eastern Time
   - (C) 7 p.m. Eastern Time
   - (D) Midnight
2. **Which state finishes last, at 1 a.m. Eastern Time?**
   - (A) Georgia
   - (B) California
   - (C) Alaska
   - (D) Florida
3. **What has Georgia's Brad Raffensperger said new laws require counties to do?**
   - (A) Report results within an hour of polls closing
   - (B) Use ranked choice voting
   - (C) Wait for California
   - (D) Count for several weeks
4. **How many competitive House races does the Cook Political Report count in Florida?**
   - (A) Two
   - (B) Ninety-five
   - (C) One
   - (D) Seven competitive House races
5. **Why could control of the Senate take much longer to become clear than control of the House?**
   - (A) Because Alaska is last
   - (B) Because Georgia reports quickly
   - (C) Because California is slow-counting
   - (D) Its margins are tighter, seven states are especially competitive, and two states use ranked choice voting
6. **How long could it be before every close race is settled?**
   - (A) One hour
   - (B) Only until midnight
   - (C) Exactly 53 minutes
   - (D) Days or even weeks

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: A 4: D 5: D 6: D

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):